



Newsletter

June 2026

From the Editor – Olwyn Alexander – Welcome to the Summer 2026 newsletter. A reminder of the refresher walks led by guides taking place in June and July. There are two morning and two afternoon walks.

Tuesday 9th June **2.30 pm** Rosemary Mann *Darwin's Edinburgh*. Start at the plaque to Darwin on the rear of NMS, where Lothian Street meets West College Street.

Tuesday 16th June **10.30am** Jim Eunson *Southern Extensions to the Old Town*. Start at Infirmary Street and end in George Square.

Tuesday 23rd June **10.30 am** Eric Melvin *John Kay's Edinburgh Folk* start at the equestrian statue of King Charles behind St Giles Cathedral.

Thursday 2nd July **3.45pm** Tom Johnston *Legal Edinburgh*. Start at the Witches Well at the entrance to the Esplanade

Hands across the North Sea

The Royal Concert Band Phileutonia, a Dutch symphonic wind orchestra, has to be one of the more unusual tour groups for EFVGA. 146 players and supporters were visiting from Helmond in the Netherlands, on the occasion of their 175th anniversary to collaborate with the Peoples Ford Boghall and Bathgate Caledonia Pipe Band in a concert at the Queen's Hall and to enjoy cultural tours. Elspeth Mclean and Colin Mckerchar took supporters on a tour of Fife and St Andrews while the players rehearsed on 22nd April. The following day, 20 of us provided tours of the Old and New Town and were offered a ticket to the evening concert.



The Phileutonia, under their conductor Dirk van de Weijer, opened the concert with a selection of pieces written

especially or arranged for wind bands. They tackled an impressive range of genres such as Astor Piazzola's 'Oblivion', and 'Gaelforce' by Scottish composer, Peter Graham.

The Phileutonia then left the stage to allow room for the Boghall and Bathgate Pipe Band to stride on. I've heard many pipe bands as they marched past in a procession or played from a distant field but this was the first time I encountered them up close and personal in the intimate space of the Queen's Hall. At volume, it was a visceral experience – felt rather than heard – from the thrilling and threatening sound of snare drums in perfect unison to the roar of the pipes. At such close quarters it is possible to appreciate the skill of the players as they navigate the intricate polyrhythms of the music with precision, concentrating closely on Pipe Major Calum Watson and Drum Major Kerr McQuillan.

Both bands then came together and the musical craftsmanship of the two bands was on full display in pieces such as 'Highland Cathedral' and 'Amazing Grace'. There was a little wobble at the

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beginning of the first piece, where the pipers and the Phileutonia were slightly out of synch but this only served to highlight how challenging this musical collaboration had been and how successfully it was achieved.

At the close the Chairman of the Phileutonia, Wim van der Linden, made a moving speech thanking the musicians for their commitment to friendship and cultural exchange in a collaboration between two very different musical languages, each rooted in generations of musicians who believe that music is a shared civic art.

Thanks go to Elspeth McLean for liaising with the Phileutonia to organize the tours.

A Taste of St Giles

Fiona Watt, who volunteers as a guide at St Giles, led a tour of the cathedral. She began by answering the three most common questions from visitors: how old is the building; who was St Giles; and what denomination is the church? A small church was built in 1124 by King David 1st to venerate his devout mother Queen Margaret, but little of that early church



remains due to destruction from English armies.

The four central sandstone pillars date from late 1300s and

the distinctive tower and crown spire were added around 1495. By 1560 the basic structure was in place but the Protestant reformers removed the stained glass windows and other decorations, including a statue of the Saint and a bejewelled reliquary believed to contain his arm bone. From that time,

brick partitions separated the aisles so that four different congregations could hold services.

By the time of George IV's visit to Edinburgh in 1822, the building was in poor repair. Two major renovations were carried out in the 19th century. In the 1830's the grey ashlar stone was put on the outside of the building, and in the 1870's a major internal restoration was undertaken, financed in part by William Chambers, then Lord Provost.

St Giles was a Greek prince living as a recluse in the South of France. He kept a tame deer and legend relates that when a local king, out hunting, shot at the deer, Giles stood in the path of the arrow to protect the animal. The king, impressed with his bravery, founded a monastery for Giles who became widely venerated as patron of lepers, the outcast and infirm. An order of healing friars was associated with the early church. St Giles is also patron saint of Edinburgh.

The church is Presbyterian Church of Scotland. It holds three services on Sunday with a short midday service on weekdays. Before the Reformation it was a collegiate church, one step down from a cathedral. King Charles I made it a cathedral in 1633 in his attempt to impose Anglican practices on the Scottish Kirk and the name has stuck.

Fiona then guided us around some of the main points of interest.

William Chambers wanted this church to be the Westminster Abbey of Scotland. He removed the partitions, opened up the nave and re-introduced decoration including a Writers Corner, commemorating writers such as Robert Fergusson, Margaret Oliphant and Robert Louis Stevenson, whose plaque was designed by the American artist Augustus Saint-Gaudens and mounted in 1904. Stevenson was staying in America when

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Saint-Gaudens made sketches of him in his hotel bed, propped up with pillows and smoking a cigarette. Catering to Protestant sensibilities, Stevenson is shown in the plaque holding a pen.

A bronze sculpture of a cutty stool, designed by Merilyn Smith and paid for by subscription from 40 Scottish women in 1992, commemorates the prayer book riot of 1637 when Dean James Hannay attempted to read the order of service mandated by Charles I. Legend tells of a woman called Jenny Geddes, who threw her stool at the Dean, shouting 'Dinnae say your mass in my lug', initiating the riot. The sculpture symbolizes the way something very ordinary such as a stool becomes very powerful, leading to momentous events.

Fiona pointed out how key moments in Scottish history are present in the church, from an original National Covenant on vellum, signed by the Marquis of Montrose, whose memorial is nearby, to the corresponding memorial to the Marquis of Argyll in the opposite side of the nave. Perhaps the most impressive was the gothic splendour of the Thistle Chapel in the south-east corner with its intricate carvings in wood and stone. The Order of the Thistle dates back to 1687, when King James VII and II wanted to ensure the support of loyal Scottish Dukes and Earls. In the 20th century, it has evolved to recognize people from more ordinary backgrounds who have contributed to public life. The chapel was designed by Scottish architect Robert Lorimer and opened in 1911.

The church continues to play a central role in public life today with a vigil and service following the death of Queen Elizabeth in 2022, and in 2023 the newly crowned King Charles III was presented here with the Honours of Scotland.

Image credits: thanks to Fiona Watt for photos of the Phileutonia and St Giles Cathedral and to Gill Davidson for the photo of Comiston Tower.

Image teaser



This image shows a circular tower dovecot, originally an angle turret of former Comiston Castle, probably built in the late 16th or early 17th century and converted to a dovecot later. There is a low, narrow entrance with sandstone surround at ground level on the north-west side, which

suggests that the tower stood at the south-east corner of the castle. The initials 'WD' are cut into the lintel of the entrance. A small section of original castle wall, measuring around 1.2m thick, extends from the north side of the tower. The house is mentioned in a disposition of the lands of Colmanstoun by John Fairlie in 1608. A building and gardens are shown on the site on William Roy's survey of 1747. Later Comiston House and stables were built on the site in 1815. External inspections in 2012 & 2015 found the tower in poor repair but by 2020 the adjacent stables had been converted into a private home and the tower repaired. There is now access to it at the far end of Camus Avenue.

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The next challenge



This simple stone marker has the letters W D carved into it. Do you know where you would find it, what it represents and who put it there? You can find out on the refresher walk by Tom Johnston.

Spotlight on guides

Victor Aitken

Victor became a guide around ten years ago on the recommendation of Barbara Drummond. He vividly remembers his first assessment with Olive Morrison in the Esplanade. She insisted on asking 'Why?' each time he recited what he had learned. After 15 minutes he decided guiding wasn't for him. Later that day the Chair phoned to encourage him not to despair but to do more reading. His second assessment with Seonaid Martin went more smoothly because both Victor and his assessor had a passion for James Graham, Marquis of Montrose. However, he reflected that Olive made him a better guide because she challenged him to deepen his knowledge.

Although Victor was not able to have a career in history he grew up in a family passionate about it. The house in Tomintoul where he was born had illustrious connections, having been built by a John Macpherson, who had helped to carry the wounded Lieutenant-

General Sir John Moore from the battlefield at Corunna in the Peninsula War.

He attributes his storytelling ability to his colourful family, including his uncle Alistair who was the local souter – shoemaker – but was famous all over Scotland as a fisherman. Visitors to the town would ply him with drink and cigarettes to persuade him to take them fishing. He told a good story. For Victor that means being able to get people to 'coorie-in' to listen to a factual story enlivened with humour, rather than simply reciting facts.

Interviewing Victor, I came to realise that part of his storytelling skill lies in the use of dialogue to add drama, as he did when I asked: *what is the funniest thing you've experienced?*

I remember guiding a group from the University of Tennessee, who dragged a large case with them wherever they went. I asked them, 'What do you need the case for?' But they simply replied, 'We need it, we need it.' On the last day when the tour reached Greyfriars churchyard, they opened the case and pulled out a video camera. They said, 'Would you mind if we interviewed you?' and I said, 'Well I don't have a lot of choice.' I got full instructions including not looking at the camera. Their question: 'Do you think Walt Disney's 1952 version of Greyfriar's Bobby was a true and accurate record?' My reply: 'It was a lot more historically accurate than Braveheart!'

Who is your favourite Royal Mile character?

Joseph Knight is my favourite character. I've researched him and the events connected to the trial, and I've read the trial documents. I like to challenge the general view of Henry Dundas's input in the abolition of slavery. He is much vilified and yet he gave up the Lord

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Advocate's post to represent Knight in court. I relate his position on abolition to the way people nowadays say, 'We should all give up diesel cars' but that won't happen overnight. Changing people takes a long hard slog. I bring this story into my tours, especially with Americans. If it hadn't been for the trial of Joseph Knight and Kames' verdict that you could be a slave anywhere in the world but not in Scotland, then Frederick Douglass – an escaped slave – would never have come to Scotland. There's not a lot of interest in Frederick Douglass here, but in America he's a huge character. When he managed to return to America he became the second most photographed person next to Abraham Lincoln.

What's the most rewarding aspect of being a guide?

I enjoy meeting people and trying to impart some real history. People coming to Scotland know something about clan rivalry and something about Mary Queen of Scots. They know about throwing rubbish out the window at 10pm. I try to get them to understand that Scottish history is much more interesting. For example, for about 200 years Scotland had two royal families, descendants of Ingebiorg and Margaret of Wessex, first and second wives of Malcolm Canmore, who went at each other hammer and tongs. The issue was resolved when Alexander III was in Arbroath and one of his men killed a new-born heir at the market cross, which put an end to the rivalry.

What advice would you give to new guides?

I've mentored several guides and my advice is: do your research, make up your own tour, don't depend on listening to other people's tours and be your own person as a guide. As your own person, you will get lots of questions that you do have answers for and if you don't have answers, it's back to stage 1: do your

research. Everyone has a sphere of interest but it's important not to become too fixated on one aspect so broaden your interest over time. It's important to make sure what the guides are saying is not fabricated. You can tell historically accurate stories in an amusing way. People might wonder if you're telling the truth but they can go away and check the facts.

Painter to Queen Victoria

Following our call for anyone with a famous ancestor, Sandy Macpherson got in touch to tell us about his great grandfather, James Giles, who played a significant part in the decision by Queen Victoria and Prince Albert to purchase the estate at Balmoral and build their Scottish castle.

The Royal couple wanted to escape the smoke and smells of London and were attracted to the thought of going to Scotland, which had become fashionable thanks to the best-selling novels of Sir Walter Scott. No longer a place of uncouth inhabitants who wore strange clothes and spoke a peculiar language, it was now seen as rugged and romantic. The Queen had visited Scotland on state visits but had not ventured further north than Blair Atholl.

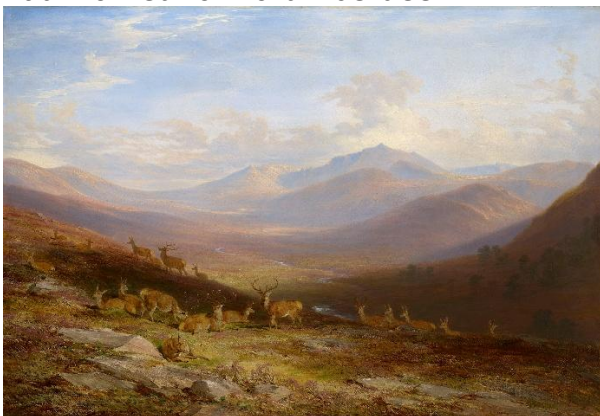
In 1847, Lord Abercorn, a courtier of Prince Albert's who rejoiced in the title Groom of the Stole, offered to sublet to the royal family a property in Inverness-shire called Ardverikie, which he leased from the Chief of Clan Macpherson. Victoria and Albert accepted this offer, setting off on 11th August in the Royal Yacht for a ten-day voyage up the West Coast of Scotland to Fort William. From there they proceeded by coach to Ardverikie, where they were met by the Clan Chief and a large crowd all in Highland dress. Although the weather was appalling, the royal family took advantage of the remoteness and

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seclusion of the location to go walking or shooting. They were invited to attend Highland Games in Laggan and to take tea with Cluny Macpherson and his wife at Cluny Castle.

Despite the bad weather, the Queen's first holiday in Scotland had given her a taste for further visits. She was advised by her Chief Physician, Sir James Clark, that Deeside might be a more suitable location with better weather. The Queen's interest in Deeside came to the attention of Lord Aberdeen, a leading politician, who had a long lease on the Balmoral Estate from the Earl of Fife.

At this point James Giles enters the story. He was an Aberdeen artist who had worked for Lord Aberdeen.



He was commissioned to paint a number of pictures of the Deeside district and the Balmoral estate for a detailed report. With only this report and the paintings to guide them, Victoria and Albert took out a five-year lease on the estate. They visited in 1848 and fell in love with the property. However, the old house was too small for the needs of their growing family so they had it demolished and the present castle erected in its place. Before the old house was demolished, the Queen instructed James Giles to execute a series of paintings of the interior, which are still in the Royal Collection.

We might have expected that James Giles would have been knighted for services to the Queen, as was his contemporary, Sir Edwin Landseer, but

the outcome for Giles was rather different. His professional fee for the paintings was delayed for a long time and he seems to have been treated unfairly in his one visit to Balmoral. In his diary he commented: "I would much rather not work for Royalty, I never made anything but a loss by it".

Book Marks

Do you have a book that has helped you to explore the history of Edinburgh? Please get in touch with the editor if you would like to submit a review.

Connecting Scotland's History

Dr Anna Groundwater, a social and cultural historian, published this little reference book in 2017 and updated it in 2025. Her aim was to bring specifically Scottish stories into the limelight, having been swamped by 300 years of British History. The pages are organized in three columns contrasting Scottish events with what was happening elsewhere in the British Isles and further afield in the rest of the world. By reading down the page, you see internal connections over time; by reading across the page you see external connections emerge. For example, on page 144, covering the first years of the 1770s we find the beginnings of the Clearances in the great Glen, invention by Richard Arkwright in Derby of a water frame for spinning cotton and Captain James Cook's voyages to Australasia. The layout of the book requires blank sections where you could add your own notes.